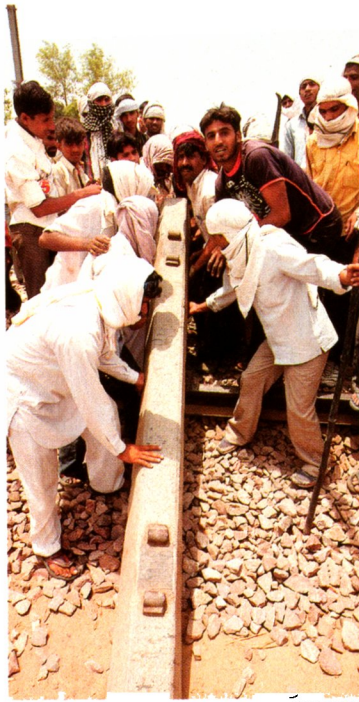




TRUCE: Raje with Bainsla in Jaipur (left), Gurjar agitators on rail tracks



SHEKHAR YADAV

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will give the Gurjars a greater share in local bodies, panchayats and employment generated within the state. They will also increase their grassroots political share in a few hundred villages and be eligible for 2,000 jobs next year. This, however, falls short of the privileges associated with ST status, which includes reservation in Central services, assembly and parliament. As Bainsla told INDIA TODAY: "Our fight to be included in Scheduled Tribes at the national level will continue."

Raje also has stopped short of meeting the Gurjar demand of sending a letter to the Centre recommending ST status. Instead, the cleverly-worded letter says, "the Government of Rajasthan endorses the averments regarding recommendations contained in letter 3.12.99", a reference to an earlier letter exchanged between the state

THE FINAL COUNT

WHAT THEY WANTED: A clear recommendation to the Centre for granting ST status to Gurjars.

WHAT THEY GOT: Five per cent reservation with benefits same as OBCs but a near-exclusive share within Rajasthan.

WHAT THEY DID NOT GET: A recommendation for ST status.

WHO GAINS, WHO LOSES: With an already granted economic package, Gurjars have achieved significantly within Rajasthan. The state loses heavily in terms of Rs 1,000-crore economic damage and more in terms of its image as a tourist and investment destination.

THE BOTTOM LINE: Raje's decision to grant reservation to Gurjars will upset political calculations and fuel the common man's anger against her failure to prevent the second phase of Gurjar agitation.

Government and the Centre. It absolves her of the charge of recommending ST status for the Gurjars which would have annoyed the politically-powerful Meenas. More significantly, the 1999 letter is believed to be based on a wrong interpretation of a state communiqué which was not exactly a recommendation. So in the end, Bainsla gets to save face and call off the agitation, but still has not got what he was hoping for an ST status or even a recommendation from the state for that. Bainsla knew the delicate nature of the talks and included a larger representation of Gurjars for negotiations to absolve himself of any charge of succumbing to government pressure. The 30-member delegation cut across political lines and had a Supreme Court lawyer, ex-army and police officers and scholars. Of the eleven leaders who were present at the final talks, six were based outside Rajasthan. Raje had set the stage by removing A.S. Gill, director-general of police, whose forces had opened fire on the agitators. She then utilised the services of other BJP leaders. Gopinath Munde stayed for two weeks in Rajasthan with Prakash Javdekar, the party spokesman who was engaged in Track 2 negotiations. Javdekar was able to mobilise his Gurjar contacts who helped in bringing Bainsla to the negotiation table. Raje depended on two trusted aides, Ram Das Aggarwal, MP, and Sunil Arora, her principal secretary and former head of Indian Airlines. Two dozen drafts were prepared, studied and abandoned before the final one. Then, all that remained was for her to convince Bainsla that this was the best deal he could get and then get him to convince his colleagues.

This is certainly not the end of the crisis. With the Gurjars not getting ST status, the issue is still not dead. She has kept the upper castes happy by granting them economic-backward reservation. But within the reserved classes, Bainsla has kept out the Rawats who are OBCs and claim to be Gurjars. The Rawats have been demanding ST status for long and could start their own agitation, as could other castes like Malis and Telis. Any further demands will anger Raje's Jat voters who form the core of her support base. Raje may have won the battle, but the caste war is far from over. ■